opening essay, asks us to notice the hardworking, mud-encrusted feet that hold up the human inside the costume.

At first glance, we could apprehend the portraits as ethnographic: descriptive of people and their cultures. But with identity and self-representation now being front and centre in cultural discourse, this is surely an outdated perspective. "My work is photographic," says Fréger. "Of course, it's connected to the work of different ethnographers and anthropologists. And sometimes people contact me believing that my work is ethnographic. But it's not, because what I'm trying to achieve first is a project based on photography. For me, doing this is an experience. It's absolutely not the idea of someone who is judging. It's more a question of being curious about the other. After a project like this, I would never consider myself a specialist in what's happening here."

A good photographer doesn't just create a frame, they draw you into it, suggesting where you might turn your gaze, hinting at where the secret to the epiphany lies. Although he appears to capture the same objectivity, Fréger disdains the lenses of Orientalism and ethnography. He does this by creating subtle disjunctions in the pictures—the field that holds the classical dancers, the tired eyes in a god's face, the feet that have done more than dance for a living—and thus, subverts the effect of the image as a whole, removing it from the frame of Otherness and 'difference'. We are fortunate that these pictures come to us in a book—we can attend to their details and extend the pleasure of seeing more and better. ■

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USTAD ABDULLAH & JEANNO GAUSSI

'Dreams on Wheels' (2013); painted by Ustad Abdullah and commissioned by Jeanno Gaussi

ART

POP GOES THE EASEL

An ongoing exhibition at KNMA brings together the best of pop art from across South Asia

Pop South Asia: Artistic Explorations in the Popular at the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA), Saket, New Delhi brings together over 100 artworks by artists from Afghanistan, Bangladesh, India, Nepal, Pakistan, Sri Lanka and the South Asian diaspora. The exhibition, which was earlier on view at the Sharjah Art Foundation, has been curated by artist Iftikhar Dadi, Cornell University professor John H. Burris and Roobina Karode, director and chief curator of KNMA.

The works span a time frame from the mid-20th century to the present, and include M.F. Husain, whose entire oeuvre could perhaps be viewed as pop art.

Meanwhile, a few artworks popped out at us. These include Sri Lankan-born Ramesh Nithiyendran's vibrantly coloured figurines, Pakistani artist Saba Khan's 'Gymkhana Ladies Swimming' and Dhaka-based Samsul Alam Helal's *Love Studio* (2010-2015) series, which references South Asian photo booths with their escapist backdrops.

The work of Tsherin Sherpa, who divides his time between Kathmandu and California, is inspired by Tibetan Buddhism but with a contemporary twist as can be seen in 'Daka' (2022). Performance artist Pushpamala N.'s 'Lakshmi' (2004) is a recreation of an oleograph by Raja Ravi Varma. While the artists, we're told, are "addressing complex issues facing the self and society", they certainly seem to be having fun while doing so. ■

Amit Dixit

(Pop South Asia *is showing at KNMA, Saket, till July 31)*

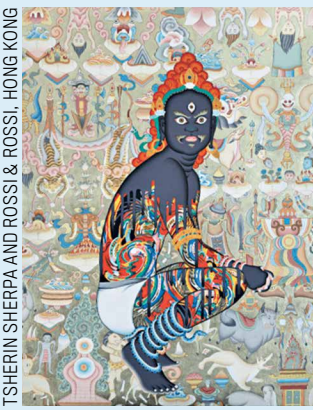
'Figure with Spiky Head II', 2022, by Ramesh Nithiyendran



JHAVERI CONTEMPORARY, MUMBAI

'Daka' (the Sky Walker), 2022, by Tsherin Sherpa

A picture from the series 'Love Studio' 2010-2015, by Samsul Alam Helal



TSHERIN SHERPA AND ROSSI & ROSSI, HONG KONG



SAMSUL ALAM HELAL



KIRAN NADAR MUSEUM OF ART, NEW DELHI

'Lakshmi' (2004) by Pushpamala N.; after an oleograph by Raja Ravi Varma